

Padea Competition

May 21st, 2026

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Overview

Padea is hiring an operations engineer – someone to fix bottlenecks in the business with AI. The first step of our selection process is completing this competition – which asks you to solve a problem similar to what you would do on the job.

The Problem

Schools partner with Padea to run weekly, small-group tutoring sessions on their campus after hours. Families enrol at the start of each term, so largely the same students attend every session that term (ignoring absences and rare mid-term enrolments). Each session includes a restaurant-catered dinner break in the middle.

Padea contracts external caterers to cook and deliver individually boxed meals (one per student) to each session. The order should arrive 5–10 minutes before the dinner break so the on-site manager can set up the meals with the delivery driver's help.

The on-site manager may collect feedback and share it with us. The on-site manager is usually the same on a given day at a given school each week (e.g. Mondays at ACME School), though this can change on one-off occasions. The caterer may contact the on-site manager's mobile to confirm arrival, report being late, or ask for help finding the session location (building and room).

Each Thursday, our program coordinator emails each caterer an order for the following week's meals, picking a few items off the caterer's menu and making an educated guess at the best meals and quantities of each meal.

Students often tell us the selected meals don't match their taste preferences. Food quality also tends to decline over time with each caterer. Ordering meals is tedious for the program coordinator – and will become a bottleneck for the business.

Your task: solve the problem from order to delivery.

Deliverables:

1. Memorandum

One-page, two-column PDF memo on your thought process throughout the task – the requirements you chose, key decisions, successes, failures, learnings... do not treat this as an assignment with a marking guide. Honest retelling > polished essay.

2. Process Diagram

A flowchart of how your solution executes the catering process from order to delivery. Show the steps, who or what does each step, and where and how the data flows.

3. Database Access

Share your database via a link. We recommend Airtable (easier) or Supabase (harder). Other tools are welcome as long as we can access the database via a link or invite.

4. Demonstration Video

Maximum five minutes showing your solution running end-to-end, including the edge cases you found. Do not treat this as a sales pitch.

5. Build Artifact

Share what you built – GitHub, exported workflows (make.com, n8n...), screenshots, etc. Ideally in a format we can review ourselves.

6. AI Usage (Optional)

Share your AI chat transcripts and/or a summary of how you used AI to build your solution.

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Resources

To solve this task, you have been given the following resources:

- caterers.xlsx
- caterer-contacts.pdf
- caterer-menus.pdf
- sessions.xlsx

- exclusions.pdf
- students.xlsx
- absences.pdf

These resources are deliberately messy – one CSV does not map to one database table and there are many hidden edge cases you will need to work out from the information. Finding them is how you accurately define the requirements for your solution – doing this well is what will set your submission apart.

While the perfect submission handles every edge case, we know many of you are close to exams. Due to this, we are open to you justifying not including edge cases in your solution to save time, as long as you have explained why it is not a priority and understanding of the edge case is shown.

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Process

We want to see how you solve problems. We recommend you follow the below problem-solving framework:

1. Make requirements less dumb

What needs to be true for the problem to be solved? Your first step should be to work out what your solution needs to do using the context shared in the resources and first principles thinking. It sounds simple, but it is wise to spend most of your time here.

2. Delete the part or process step

Draft your solution and map your process, then delete as much as you can. The most common error of a smart person is to optimise the thing that should not exist. Delete so that at least some of the things you delete, you will put back in.

3. Simplify or optimise

Take the remaining part or process step and ask: is there a simpler way to do this? Fewer tables, fewer fields, fewer steps, fewer decisions, fewer tools. Less is more – faster to build, easier to maintain, harder to break.

4. Accelerate cycle time

Make it faster (more complex, so skipping over this – if you are curious, watch the Elon Musk videos linked below).

5. Automate

Only after your process is as small, simple, and fast as possible should you automate what is left. This is where AI and your build come in. Do not automate something that should not exist.

This is not my framework. It is Elon Musk's. Feel free to hear it in his own words [here](#), [here](#) and [here](#).

While automation and AI are a big part of the role and why it is exciting, your problem-solving and critical-thinking abilities are more important.

This is tested most in Steps 1 to 4, and we are looking at how you complete these four steps just as much as, if not more than, the final automation step. Steps 1 to 4 will define the quality of your Step 5 (automation) and submission.

When defining your requirements and building your process, think – what is the purpose of catering in the business? Then, what is the goal of this system? *Hint: it is not just that meals are ordered and delivered each week.*

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Automation

We recommend that your system has the three layers below. The tools you use to fulfil the layers are up to you.

1. LLM

The brain or “intelligence” for your system. We recommend using Claude. We are able to give you access to Claude Code on request.

2. Database and State

We recommend Airtable (easier) or Supabase (harder) as your data layer. You are able to create free accounts on both.

3. Tools and Glue

Options range from no-code orchestration (make.com/n8n) to agentic orchestration (Claude Code) to actual code. We are also able to give you access to Fillout Forms as a tool on request.

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Learning

To succeed in this competition (and the role), you will need to self-direct much of your own learning. Here is some useful content to start you off on what to look for.

Brain/Tools:

[Nick Saraev](#) is the best creator we have found for learning AI (i.e. how to set up the brain and tools):

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QoQBzR1NIql&t=442s>
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sduaTkhlm_w
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EsTrWCV0Ph4&t=617s>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UPtmKh1vMN8&t=19s>

Databases:

We recommend you build a basic foundation in relational databases (especially junction tables). You will naturally figure out how databases work as you try to solve the problem – if you learnt specialist mathematics and special relativity, you can learn this.

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zsivFFK0m3c&t=26s>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wR0jg0eQsZA>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NvrpuBAMddw>

Prompting:

Mantra: If a human (you) could not accurately follow your instructions, an AI will not either.

- <https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/overview>
- <https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/claude-prompting-best-practices>

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Timeline

Heats Round

21st of May 2026	Release of task sheet
29th of May 2026 (11:59pm)	Heats submission deadline via email to dylan@padea.com.au
1st of June 2026	Heats presentation (for shortlisted candidates)

Finals Round

3rd of June 2026	Finalists notified
6th of June 2026 (11:59pm)	Finals submission deadline via email to dylan@padea.com.au
8th of June 2026	Finals presentation
10th of June 2026	Winners notified

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Criteria

We will be judging your submissions against three criteria:

1. Functionality

How not dumb are your requirements? How optimised is your solution to these requirements? How well executed is your automation of the solution?

2. Learning

How much new knowledge did you create? What was your rate of improvement? What decisions did you make and why? This will be judged from your memo.

3. Taste

We are keeping this criterion deliberately vague. Do you value beautiful things? Do you make your work good for the sake of it being good? We value refined judgement.